

# Aesthetic Language: Exploring the Interplay between Language, Art, and the Sensible

Yekta Jokar

Université Paris-VIII-Vincennes-Saint-Denis

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*“There are, indeed, things that cannot be put into words. They make themselves manifest. They are what is mystical.” (Wittgenstein, Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus, 6.522)*

Upon reading this phrase, many questions rushed into my mind. What are the limits of language? How does the unsayable manifest itself? What is this notion of mystical? Can art transcend the limitations of language? Can language itself transcend its limitations?

These questions led me to a journey of investigating the expressive capacities of art and language, expressing what cannot be put into words in a discursive and conceptual manner. I arrived at the idea of an “Aesthetic language”. Here, I’m using the term Aesthetic in its broad sense, the investigation of that which belongs to the realm of sensibility, According to H. Appelqvist in her Wittgenstein and Aesthetics.

*“Aesthetics is explicitly contrasted with the conceptual domain of logic. Sensible perception, imagination, and feeling are treated as a realm independent of and irreducible to the discursive realm of concepts, contributing to cognition of its own terms.” (Appelqvist, 2023, p.1)*

With this sense of Aesthetic in mind, when I talk about an Aesthetic language, I don’t mean a kind of language that deals with beauty, rather a kind of language that belongs and has access to the realm of the sensible. How can language, a logical structure, interact with the sensible?

This exploration delves deeper as we encounter the limitations of language in representing certain aspects of reality. The concept of the Mystical, prevalent in Wittgenstein's work, embodies this notion of the ineffable. Early in his philosophy, Wittgenstein explored the idea that language, with its logical structure, is ill-equipped to describe certain aspects of reality. The Mystical becomes a prime example: it represents experiences that transcend the limitations of language, existing in the realm of feeling, intuition, or pure experience.

In my future work, I will argue that language has expressive capacities beyond merely representing reality. I try to answer the questions I mentioned earlier and other questions that come along with them. My main objective is to investigate the expressive and aesthetic capacities of language within various conceptual frameworks. I will look for an “Aesthetic language”, meaning a kind of language that goes beyond its logical limitations, a kind of language that shows instead of saying.

The notion of mystical appears throughout Wittgenstein's work from the *Tractatus* to his later works like *Philosophical Investigations*. As his philosophy shifted, this notion disappears from his writing. Mystical in his early philosophy referred to what cannot be said, what lies beyond the limitation of language, what shows itself. Mystical is the aspect of reality that eludes the capacity of language to describe, because language is constructed around logical structure and the mystical transcends this structure. The phrase with which I started this exploration suggests that mystical is what is experienced but escapes linguistic expression.

I encourage you to look at language as a form of art and art as a form of language. None of these assertions are definitively true nor are they false. Despite being distinct concepts, they have numerous similarities and an interconnectedness which allows them to function interchangeably. If we look closely at them with a later Wittgensteinian approach, it seems that they share crucial resemblances; As Morris Weitz did in his influential work *The Role of Theory in Aesthetics*. Wittgenstein's approach in the *Philosophical Investigations* is markedly different from his early work in that he shifts from a focus on the structure of language and the limits of what can be said to an exploration of how language is used in practice, emphasizing the diversity and complexity of language games in our daily interactions. This later Wittgenstein is more concerned with the way words acquire their meaning through their use in specific contexts. The mystical, in the context of his later work, might be considered as that which we accept as part of our form of life and the background against which we understand the world, without seeking to explain it using language. Yet, I decided to use the term “sensible” from Deleuze’s philosophy to describe those parts of reality that are immediately experienced or perceived. The reason for this is that despite Wittgenstein and Deleuze’s approaches being evidently quite different and at times opposing each other, there are still similarities worth exploring. I think that combining Deleuze's idea of the sensible and Wittgenstein's idea of the mystical enriches our understanding of language shaping our human experience.

In my inquiry, I will be using the works of three influential philosophers of the 20<sup>th</sup> century from three different schools: Wittgenstein from the analytic tradition, Deleuze from the continental tradition, and Dewey from the pragmatic tradition. This mix may seem odd, especially since Deleuze refers to Wittgenstein as “une catastrophe”, but this choice is guided by deliberate justifications.

Above all, All three philosophers are concerned with language and meaning to some degree. My investigation began when I was introduced to Wittgenstein's philosophy of language. Both the *Tractatus* and *Philosophical Investigations* gave me insights into the matter and provoked essential questions about language, meaning and expression which brought forth other questions about reality, human experience, cognition and Finally Aesthetics in its broad sense.

My main question was formed: How can language transcend its logical limitations and move to realm of the sensible? Soon I realized for the purpose of forming a strong foundation for my investigation I need to incorporate the works of other philosophers which could complement the works of Wittgenstein and give me insights into the matter where he decides to remain silent.

On the other hand, one rather important thing that these philosophers share is their criticism of essentialism. All three philosophers consistently argue against different aspects of essentialism. Wittgenstein's anti-essentialist stance became more explicit and central in his later philosophy, he argues against the idea of fixed, essential meaning for words or concepts, instead highlighting their fluidity and dependance on context and use: The meaning of a word is its use in language. (Wittgenstein, 1958. §43 )

Similarly, John Dewey (e.g., *Experience and Nature*) argued against fixed, static conceptions of reality, knowledge, and human nature. He believed that essentialism tended to reify abstract categories and concepts, ignoring the dynamic and evolving nature of experience. Dewey emphasized the importance of context, process, and change in understanding the world, which stood in contrast to the essentialist tendency to focus on fixed essences or eternal truths.

Needless to say, Deleuze's philosophy is characterized by a rejection of essentialism and a focus on becoming, difference and multiplicity: The concept is not a representation that reflects a pre-existing object, nor is it a subjective state that expresses an internal life. It is a process of differentiation, a production of difference within the field of immanence. (Deleuze, 1994, p. 171)

The anti-essentialism that can be seen in all three philosophies leads to another similarity worthy of attention; words do not have fixed, pre-determined meanings. These three philosophers all agreed that language is fluid and meaning is contextual. Deleuze, Dewey and later Wittgenstein all held that language is not merely a passive representation of reality and pre-existing truths or entities. They argue that language is not simply a mirror of reality but actively participates in shaping our understanding of the world. Language is a creative and productive force that generates meaning rather than merely transmits it. It is not just a neutral medium for conveying information but actively influences how we perceive and interpret reality. Through its use in communication, inquiry, and social interaction, language contributes to the construction of our cognitive frameworks and cultural perspectives. They also emphasize the dynamic and fluid nature of meaning, which emerges through the practical use of language in specific contexts. Meaning is not something inherent in words or concepts but is continuously negotiated and constructed through ongoing interactions and experiences.

*For a large class of cases—though not for all—in this way we can arrange the things between which there must be a certain order in order that language should function at all. (Wittgenstein, 1958., §124 )*

Language is a social product; it is not a mere instrument for the communication of ready-made ideas, but a means for creating them. (Dewey, 1916. Chapter 8)

*The whole system of signs constitutes a process of becoming, a perpetual transformation. There is no language in itself, but only languages in the process of being made and unmade. (Deleuze, & Guattari, 1987, pg. 7)*

In addition to these similarities, the differences and the uniqueness of their philosophies can be complementary. I will further discuss how these unique philosophies can help us to have a better understanding of language and its relationship with experience and the sensible.

Gilles Deleuze's philosophy emphasizes the dynamic nature of reality, highlighting concepts such as the sensible, immanence, and becoming, which suggest that language and art actively shape our understanding of reality and lived experiences (Deleuze & Guattari, 1987). Deleuze challenges the notion that language and art merely represent pre-existing truths, instead viewing them as active forces that contribute to the creation and transformation of reality. This perspective encourages us to engage with language as a tool for shaping our world actively. Deleuze's emphasis on the fluidity and multiplicity of meanings allows for experimentation and innovation in language use, blurring the boundaries between the logical and the aesthetic. Furthermore, by viewing language as an active force in shaping perception and experience, Deleuze's ontology invites exploration of how language can engage with sensibility, evoking and communicating sensory experiences beyond traditional linguistic boundaries (Deleuze, 1994). In his framework, examples play a crucial role in reinventing aesthetic language and experience, illustrating the dynamic interplay between the real and the virtual and showcasing the transformational power of creative experimentation and invention.

Dewey's holistic view emphasizes the integration of aesthetic experiences into everyday life, highlighting their pervasive influence beyond traditional artistic realms (Dewey, 1916; Dewey, 1925). Through a pragmatic lens, he emphasizes the contextual significance of these encounters, acknowledging the role of social interaction and ongoing processes in shaping meaning. By expanding the scope of aesthetic language to encompass daily activities, Dewey underscores how art can enhance ordinary experiences, fostering creativity and deepening engagement with the world. Dewey's perspective emphasizes that aesthetic experiences aren't isolated occurrences but are deeply intertwined with our daily lives, enriching our experiences beyond traditional artistic contexts. His pragmatic philosophy stresses the importance of context, process, and social interaction in shaping meaning and experience. By considering these factors, research acknowledges that aesthetic experiences are deeply influenced by the specific contexts in which they occur, as well as the ongoing processes of perception, interpretation, and

interaction. Dewey's belief that aesthetic encounters are integral to daily activities expands the scope of aesthetic language beyond traditional art forms, highlighting how aesthetic experiences can be found in a wide range of human expressions, interactions, and environments. This perspective recognizes the transformative power of art and aesthetic encounters in making meaning, fostering creativity, and deepening our engagement with the world around us (Dewey, 1931; Dewey, 1934).

Incorporating Wittgenstein's perspectives on language games and the mystical into the exploration of aesthetic language reveals language's capacity to convey complex emotions and experiences beyond its logical confines, emphasizing its practical, context-dependent nature in articulating the ineffable aspects of human experience. His concepts of language games and the mystical highlight the ways in which language can show rather than say, illuminating the expressive power of language beyond its logical structure. Wittgenstein's emphasis on the practical use of language and the context-dependent nature of meaning encourages a more nuanced exploration of how language operates within different forms of life, making it possible to articulate the unsayable aspects of human experience. Wittgenstein's concept of language games illustrates how language operates within specific contexts, highlighting its multifaceted nature, while the notion of the mystical underscores the idea that language can convey meaning beyond the realm of logical propositions, emphasizing its expressive power. Wittgenstein suggests that language has the capacity to "show" aspects of reality rather than simply "say" them, illuminating the ability of language to convey complex emotions, experiences, and aesthetics that may defy straightforward description. Furthermore, Wittgenstein emphasizes the practical use of language and the context-dependent nature of meaning, encouraging a nuanced exploration of how language functions within different social, cultural, and personal contexts, allowing for a deeper understanding of human experience. By acknowledging the limits of language and its ability to express the ineffable, Wittgenstein's framework enables us to articulate aspects of human experience that may be difficult or impossible to express directly through language, opening up new avenues for exploring the rich and diverse dimensions of aesthetic language and human communication. (Wittgenstein, *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus*, 6.522; Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*)

Later philosophy of language developed by Wittgenstein stresses the significance of language games and the contextual character of meaning. As to Wittgenstein, language is a dynamic activity moulded by its usage in particular social and cultural settings rather than a static system of symbols with fixed meanings. This perspective is consistent with the idea of immediate experience put forward by Dewey, which stresses the ongoing flow of lived experience and the function of language in forming and articulating it. For Dewey and Wittgenstein alike, language is fundamental to our perception of and interpretation of the outside world. They both highlight

the dynamic nature of language, emphasizing its role in shaping our understanding of reality and mediating our experiences. (Wittgenstein, 1958a; Dewey, 1916)

These philosophers' holistic perspective offers a thorough foundation for understanding the intricacies of language, art, and expression, notwithstanding their disparities. Let us examine some of their primary distinctions and highlight their commonalities even more: Wittgenstein highlights the way that language is ingrained in certain social activities and practices and the part language games play in forming meaning. Dewey, however, emphasises how language changes and adapts within communities across time and concentrates more on the social and historical background of language usage. Though Wittgenstein and Dewey both concentrate mostly on language and how it shapes understanding, Deleuze broadens his perspective to include ontology and subjectivity. The topic is given a metaphysical depth by Deleuze's focus on becoming and transformation, which examines how language and art shape our understanding of reality and our experience of it.

Wittgenstein's later philosophy emphasizes the ephemeral and context-dependent aspect of meaning and is marked by skepticism towards the idea of expressing stable truths or essences via language. Though his emphasis is more on the practical effects of beliefs and ideas than on their language expression, Dewey also questions essentialist views of truth. With his ontology of being, Deleuze completely rejects fixed categories and essences in favor of a process-oriented understanding of reality in which truth is dynamic and contextually located (Wittgenstein, 1953; Dewey, 1916; Deleuze & Guattari, 1987).

Expanding upon this basis, the aesthetic component of experience is provocatively explored in Gilles Deleuze's philosophy of art. Deleuze abandons representational conceptions of art in favour of an ontology of being in which art is used to investigate and develop novel ways of being. According to Deleuze's ontology, art is a dynamic process of experimentation and metamorphosis as much as a mirror of reality (Deleuze & Guattari, 1987). This viewpoint offers up fresh opportunities for aesthetic expression and understanding while forcing us to reevaluate how language shapes our understanding of reality.

When these viewpoints are combined, it becomes clear how intricately language, aesthetics, and ontology interact. According to Wittgenstein and Dewey, language is essential to creating our understanding of reality and mediating our experience of the world. Deleuze's ontology simultaneously serves as a reminder that reality is not fixed but rather always in flux and

that language and art are potent instruments for investigating and engaging in this continuing process of being (Deleuze, 1994). Given this perspective, language becomes more than just a means of representation or communication; it is a dynamic and creative force that moulds our understanding of reality and creates new opportunities for aesthetic experience. By accepting the ideas of Wittgenstein, Dewey, and Deleuze, we may better comprehend the complex interaction between language, aesthetics, and ontology and investigate the rich fabric of human experience that is situated at their meeting point (Dewey, 1916; Wittgenstein, 1953; Deleuze & Guattari, 1987).

Some might argue that even language that evokes emotions is still ultimately logical. For example, a metaphor might create a feeling of sadness, but the comparison itself relies on a logical connection between two things (Deleuze & Guattari, 1994). Yet, while the underlying structure of language might be logical, the aesthetic experience focuses on the emotional impact and sensory details that go beyond the purely logical meaning of the words.

It is important to mention that there are notable differences in the ways these three minds delve deeper into the matter. For instance, Wittgenstein emphasizes the role of language games in shaping meaning, while Dewey might focus on the social and historical context of language use and Deleuze extends his view into ontology and subjectivity, exploring the creative and transformative potential of language in shaping our understanding of the world. This particular similarity is most important for my work because despite these differences in emphasis and approach, the overarching, fundamental agreement on the fluidity, contextuality, and active role of language in shaping our understanding of the world is a significant point of convergence among Deleuze, Dewey, and later Wittgenstein. This shared perspective offers me a rich foundation for exploring the complexities of linguistic expression and its implications for human thought, communication, and experience.

Examples are essential for understanding and engaging with aesthetic language from each of the philosophical views. Examples provide light on the subtle links that exist between language, experience, and expression. These examples may be found in poetry, figurative language, literature, or even the nuanced weight of specific words. They invite individuals to investigate the limitless possibilities of aesthetic engagement. The importance of examples in understanding language is emphasised by Wittgenstein's later philosophy, which is notably elaborated in the *Philosophical Investigations*. The meaning of words, according to Wittgenstein's point of view, is based on how they are used inside certain language games or settings (Wittgenstein, 1953). In terms of aesthetic language, one may make the case that contextual examples are as important for understanding and appreciating creative expression. Paintings are

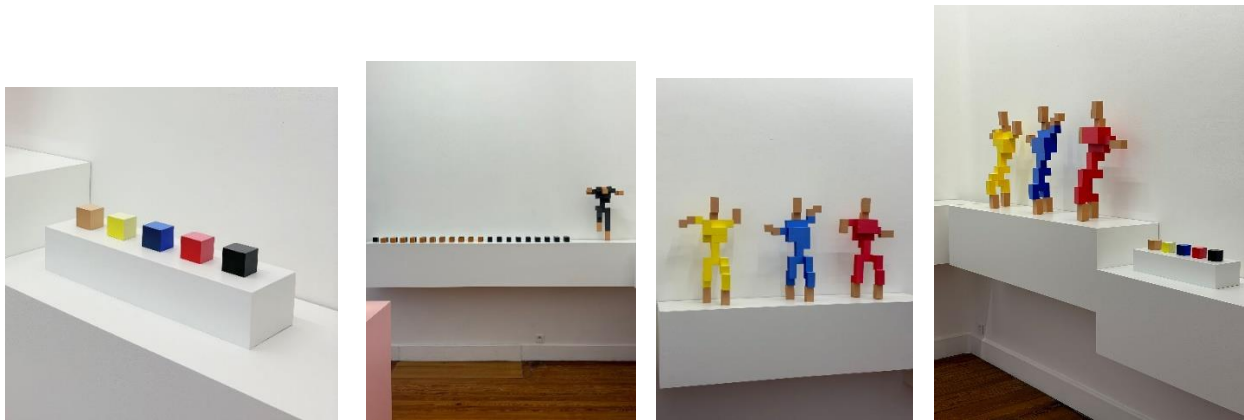
examples of the richness and variety of aesthetic language, illustrating how meaning develops from the interaction of form, context, and interpretation. In the same way that Wittgenstein could demonstrate the usage of a term via examples, artworks are examples of the richness and diversity of aesthetic language. To demonstrate this, I will use two examples where language functions as art and art as language:



Sisyphus, Painting by Titian, 1548 or 1549.

The story of Sisyphus, drawn from Greek mythology, encapsulates profound themes and emotions that transcend its literal narrative. Sisyphus, condemned to an eternal punishment of futile labor by the gods, symbolizes the perpetual struggle and quest for meaning inherent in the human condition. Through symbolism and metaphor, the tale communicates existential insights, echoing Wittgenstein's notion of "showing versus saying." Albert Camus, in his renowned essay "The Myth of Sisyphus," interprets Sisyphus's plight as a reflection of the absurdity of human existence. Despite the apparent meaninglessness of his task, Sisyphus's relentless effort to push the boulder uphill signifies a defiance against fate and a pursuit of significance. This illustrates how storytelling, like art, captures the intricacies of human experience and invites philosophical contemplation. Furthermore, what makes the story fascinating is its ability to convey profound themes such as the meaning of life and human suffering without explicit narration. It exemplifies how art and language intertwine, blurring the line between linguistic and visual expression. In the realm of aesthetic language, this story paints a vivid picture that transcends mere words, inviting interpretation and contemplation.

Transitioning to art, I'd like to share sculptures crafted during my tenure, Sepand Danesh, as a studio assistant. These sculptures, composed of individual cubes, gain unique meaning within their compositional context. While the cubes may appear identical in isolation, their arrangement within the composition imbues them with individuality, contributing to a unified whole. These sculptures challenge our understanding of the world and ourselves, presenting different interpretations based on context. They perpetually evoke immediate aesthetic experiences, shaping reality through experience, meaning, ideas, and forms. By showcasing these sculptures, I aim to illustrate the essence of aesthetic language, where the distinction between representation and reality becomes increasingly nuanced.



In conclusion, my exploration sets the stage for a deeper investigation into the concept of aesthetic language, transcending traditional boundaries to engage with the sensory and ineffable. By integrating the perspectives of Wittgenstein, Deleuze, and Dewey, I aim to contribute to the unraveling of the dynamic, contextual, and transformative nature of both language and art. This foundational work marks the beginning of a broader inquiry into the expressive potential of language and art, as well as the profound depths of human experience.

Moreover, it offers potential insights that could be a part of the discussions in philosophy, aesthetics, and artistic practice, contributing to our understanding of human cognition, communication, and even neuroaesthetics. Furthermore, it stimulates additional inquiries that sustain the ongoing discourse: What happens to the notion of mystical in Wittgenstein's later philosophy? In what ways does the power of a picture exceed the limitations of language, enabling it to convey emotions, concepts, and experiences that elude verbal expression? Is Aesthetic Language a type of expression, or does it embody the overarching aesthetic essence inherent in all forms of expression?

Lastly, a significant convergence emerges from the collective insights of Wittgenstein, Dewey, and Deleuze, emphasizing the fluidity, contextuality, and active role of language in shaping understanding. Together, these thinkers contribute to a rich tradition of anti-essentialist thought, challenging fixed categories, essences, and truths for a more adaptable, context-driven understanding of reality. This holistic understanding illuminates the complex interplay between language, art, and expression, offering a comprehensive view of how they shape our perceptions, experiences, and interactions with the world, paving the way for a deeper appreciation of human expression and the potential of aesthetic language.

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